

GIRLS BASKETBALL: STATE TOURNAMENT

Lavender leads CCC into finals

The Associated Press

COLUMBUS — Ohio's Ms. Basketball Jantel Lavender scored 14 points and hit the go-ahead basket midway through the fourth quarter and Cleveland Central Catholic pulled away late to beat Versailles 51-39 in the Division III state semifinals on Thursday.

The 6-foot-4 Lavender dominated around the glass, pulling down 14 rebounds and blocking five shots for the No. 3 Ironmen, who advanced to their first state championship.

With the game tied at 34 in the fourth quarter, Lavender hit a hook shot to touch off a six-point run for the Ironmen (24-1).

Second-team all-Ohioan Justine Raterman, shut down for most of the first half, hit a jumper to pull the 10th-ranked Tigers (23-4) to within 42-38, but Angela Bryant scored on a jumper and Lavender made two foul shots.

Bryant came off the bench to score 13 points for Central Catholic. Second-team all-Ohioan Candyce Flynn had 10 points.

Raterman finished with 13 points for Versailles, making its third appearance in the state tournament. She also had seven rebounds. Emily Bohman had eight points, six in the first quarter, and nine boards.

Central Catholic's aggressive defense forced 11 steals, many in the first half, and Versailles had 18 turnovers. The Ironmen missed several layups in the first half that kept the game close.

Neither team shot well. Central Catholic made just 35 percent of its shots (19-of-53) and Versailles made 31 percent (15-of-48).

Lavender rebounded her own shot and scored to tie the game at 14 in the second quarter and start at nine-point run. Megan Shardo made a layup just before the half to cut the lead to one at the half.

Delphos St. John's 55, Albany Alexander 24

Jeanne Bockey and Brittany Pohlman scored 11 points apiece and Delphos St. John's stifling defense limited Albany Alexander to just eight baskets in beating the Spartans 55-24 in the other Division III state semifinal.

The 24 points were the fewest

ever in the Division III semifinals, two points below the 26 scored by Ironton in the 2005 semifinals.

Kim Miller had six points and six rebounds in the first quarter to jump start the Blue Jays, who shot just 18 percent (3-of-17) from the field in the first quarter and had nine points. She finished with eight points and a game-high nine rebounds.

Bockey and Pohlman led a balanced attack. Alisha Byrne hit three 3-pointers and Zefiryn Bryan added eight points for No. 4 Delphos, a five-time state champion.

The Blue Jays (25-1) held Alexander (24-3) to just 20 percent shooting (8-of-40), outrebounded the Spartans 45-19 and forced 18 turnovers. The Spartans, making their first appearance in the state tournament, once went more than six minutes without scoring.

First-team all-Ohio selection Kellee Guthrie, who averages 19 points a game, scored just two on 1-of-7 shooting from the field. Whitney Smith and Jami Turrill, who each average 14 points a game, combined to score just six points.

Amy Smith led Albany with 10 points and Lauren Raines had seven rebounds.

After their slow start, the Blue Jays made 51 percent of their shots (18-of-35) for the rest of the game.

Bockey hit a 3-pointer to open the second quarter and give the Blue Jays a 12-5 lead. She scored seven points in the second quarter and Pohlman scored four as Delphos outscored Alexander 20-7 in the second quarter to take a 29-12 halftime lead.

Division II

Hathaway Brown 47, Sandusky Perkins 39

Mylan Woods scored 11 of her 15 points in the second half and hit a key jumper late in the game to lead Shaker Heights Hathaway Brown to a 47-39 victory over Sandusky Perkins in the Division II state semifinals on Thursday.

Woods, a second team all-Ohioan, was 7-of-10 from the field, and hit a jump shot in the lane midway through the fourth quarter after the Pirates had cut the Blazers' seven-point lead to one, 34-33.

Alexis Dobbs finished with 13 points for the Blazers (22-4), who will make their first appearance in the state championship Saturday.

Warsaw River View 57, Cols. Eastmoor 41

Kristin Daugherty scored 30 points to lead defending state champion Warsaw River View.

Daugherty, the co-player of the year in Division II, was 11-of-17 from the field as the No. 2 Black Bears (25-1) shot 63 percent (12-of-19) from the field in the second half to pull away against the Warriors (19-5).

THE TOURNAMENT TRAIL: BOYS REGIONAL BASKETBALL



STEVE MANHEIM / CHRONICLE

Olmsted Falls' Tim Mansell (44) greets Tyler Sparks as he leaves the court as the clock winds down in the Bulldogs' win over Kenmore in Canton. The Bulldogs overcame a lot of obstacles to beat the Cardinals and advance to Saturday's final.

Bulldogs a resilient bunch

Pete Alpern
The Chronicle-Telegram

CANTON — Tyler Sparks' voice was inaudible amid the clamor inside Canton Memorial Field House. The Akron Kenmore Cardinals had swept momentum onto their side and midway through the third quarter they were heading back to the free throw line, further cutting into Olmsted Falls' lead.

As the Bulldogs took their positions, Sparks made sure to make piercing eye contact with each of his teammates.

"Keep moving," he mouthed.

If his words weren't heard, they were certainly understood. Olmsted Falls overcame multiple obstacles in reaching the Division II regional finals Thursday in a 58-48 victory over Akron Kenmore.

Not the least of those hurdles was a resilient Cardinals team that forced the Bulldogs to abandon their patented full-court style and revert to a bruising deliberate game.

The Bulldogs are nothing if not poised. They didn't buckle under the weight of the team's three tops scorers — Sparks, Dave Pellerite and Pat Pellerite — being saddled on the bench with foul trouble throughout the second half.

They didn't break under the pressure of Kenmore's overwhelming advantages in height. And they certainly didn't falter when the shots stopped falling and the Cardinals were knipping at their heels.

Much of that is a product of Sparks' cool disposition. But it also reflects the manner of the team's core.

"We knew that it was only a matter of time before we stopped them from scoring every time down the floor," said senior point guard Mike Stallard. "That's how it

goes in basketball. There are runs. They go on one, but so will we."

Which helps explain, in part, why Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue — normally a pretty animated character on the bench, feverishly pacing to and fro, belting out orders to his players — was quiet as a mouse alongside his assistants.

"We weren't sitting there, going, 'Oh my lord, what are we going to do?'" said Donahue. "We've been in that situation numerous times during the year. And one thing this team doesn't do is hit the panic button."

One would have to go back to a Jan. 19 loss to North Olmsted to find a comparable performance by the Bulldogs. Olmsted Falls shot 3-for-13 during the third quarter against Kenmore.

Dave Pellerite was on the floor for only 90 seconds before picking up his third foul and being sent to the bench.

The Bulldogs missed 10 of its first 17 free throws in the fourth quarter.

Lastly, Sparks and the Pellerite brothers combined to hit just 13 of 31 shots from the field for the game.

"It was definitely frustrating all the way around," said Pat Pellerite, who scored 10 points. "It was hard to get into the groove of the game when you're in foul trouble. But that's why our bench has been so important."

Senior Kyle Bungard was sensational, scoring 10 points in reserve, while junior Jim Brabenec provided key minutes and grabbed two steals.

The Bulldogs also got an assist from the Cardinals, who missed 13 of their first 17 free throws.

Just as important, junior point guard Marcus Golden was held to just 10 points — nearly half of his season average. Gold-

en appeared like a kid in a candy shop in the early going, dazzling the crowd with his array of crossovers and spins.

"He's the reason we couldn't run our press," Sparks said. "He broke the press, all by himself. He's just a quick little guy and ran right through us."

It was Stallard's job to stay with him — which is no small task. But by the fourth quarter, Stallard was scowling, muttering to himself as shot after shot deflected harmlessly off the rim.

"I just tried to stay with him," Stallard said. "It didn't always work because that kid's so fast. But I tried to keep him to one side, so that he had only half the court. Then I could only hope that my teammates would give some help."

So now Olmsted Falls turns its attention to its regional championship opponent, Upper Sandusky, which defeated Van Wert in Toledo on Thursday.

It will present a radically different style of basketball.

"Oh, it'll be totally different," Donahue said. "Both teams will be whipping it up and down the court every time. It'll be fun for sure."

How fun?

Well, Upper Sandusky, led by Jon Diebler, the career scoring leader in Ohio high school boys basketball history, scored a combined 296 points in three postseason performances before compiling 79 on Thursday.

Which should provide just one more obstacle in the Bulldogs' way.

Contact Pete Alpern at 329-7136 or palpern@chronicle.com.

MEET THE ALL-STARS

SENIOR GIRLS ALL-STAR GAMES
Monday at Keystone High School
Game 1 at 6 p.m., Game 2 at 8 p.m.
2007 Ms. Basketball announced between games

Admiral King



Latasha Kimbro

Basketball varsity letters: 2
2006-07 statistics: Field-goal percentage — 51; Foul-shooting percentage — 80; Rebounds per game — 2; Assists per game — 1; Total points (2006-07) — 90.
Plans: Attend the University of Akron to study mass media communications.



Brittney Smith

Basketball varsity letters: 4
2006-07 statistics: Field-goal percentage — 60; Foul-shooting percentage — 50; Assists per game — 1; Points per game — 2.4.
Plans: Attend the Ohio State University to study sports medicine, physical therapy or pharmacy



Dominique Starr

Basketball varsity letters: 4
2006-07 statistics: Field-goal percentage — 65; Foul-shooting percentage — 58; Rebounds per game — 6; Assists per game — 1; Points per game — 10.
Plans: Attend Case Western Reserve University to study sports medicine.

Amherst



Callie Brucher

Basketball varsity letters: 4
2006-07 statistics: Field-goal percentage — 42; Foul-shooting percentage — 63; Points per game — 13.8; Rebounds per game — 7.2; Assists per game — 1.2.
Plans: Attend the University of Findlay and study psychology.



Maddie Sofia

Basketball varsity letters: 3
2006-07 statistics: Field-goal percentage — 38; Foul-shooting percentage — 66; Points per game — 11.0; Rebounds per game — 3; Assists per game — 1.6.
Plans: Attend Mount Union College of the College of Wooster and study veterinary medicine.



Allison Theobald

Basketball varsity letters: 2
2006-07 statistics: Field-goal percentage — 29; Foul-shooting percentage — 39; Points per game — 2; Rebounds per game — 1.2; Assists per game — 1.

FALLS

From B1

"When you're a player like him, that's what's expected. I'm very proud of Tyler."

Sparks will be playing basketball for the University of Findlay next year.

"He should be a Division I college player," Donahue said. "The Division I coaches say he's not athletic enough. I don't know how he's not athletic enough. All I know is Findlay is getting a great player."

Sparks helped Olmsted Falls to a 28-18 halftime lead with six points, eight rebounds and four assists. The Bulldogs hit only 12 of 31 field-goal attempts in the first half, but bothered Kenmore (16-7) into 12 turnovers while committing only five themselves.

All that changed in the third quarter as Kenmore scored nine points in the first 2:32 to make it a 28-27 game. The Cardinals could have taken the lead at 5:04 of the period, but Marcus Golden missed two free throws.

Foul shooting let down Kenmore most of the game. The Cards made only four of their first 16 shots at the line and were 8-of-21 for the evening.

Sparks stopped the bleeding with a three-point play at 4:37 of the third. Bungard's 3-point-er made it 34-29 and two foul shots by Sparks gave the Bulldogs a 36-31 lead.

Then came the bomb that gave Falls the upper hand heading into the final eight-minute installment. It mitigated a quarter in which the Bulldogs were just 3-of-13 from the field.

"I think (the shot) made us say,

"OK, let's start playing now," Sparks said. "We thought, 'We got that third quarter out of us, now let's get it together for the fourth.'"

Falls got its defense together. The Bulldogs overcame uncharacteristic poor free throw shooting (11-of-21). Kenmore, however, made only 5 of 16 field-goal tries in the final period, with three of those baskets coming in the final half-minute. The Cards were 2-of-11 from the field in the fourth with the game still within reach.

"This was a confidence-builder," Sparks said. "I wouldn't say we played our best game, but we stuck together and got through it. That's what you need at this time of the year."

The Bulldogs were 19-of-55 from the field (35 percent). Bungard and Pat Pellerite added 10 points each. Pellerite scored nine of his points in the first half.

Kenmore hit 19 of 48 field-goal attempts. Joe Miller led Kenmore with 14 points before fouling out with 6:20 to play. Golden was held to 10 points, almost 10 points below his season average.

Olmsted Falls 58, Kenmore 48

OLMSTED FALLS (58): Mike Stallard 2-2-6, Dave Pellerite 3-0-7, Tyler Sparks 6-6-19, Alex Sedley 1-2-4, Pat Pellerite 4-1-10, Kyle Bungard 3-2-10, Brandon Melbar 0-0-0, Mark Hurrell 0-0-0, Kevin Moennich 0-0-0, Jim Brabenec 0-0-0, Scott Kimmey 0-2-2, Tim Mansell 0-0-0. Totals 18-15-58.
KENMORE (48): Marcus Golden 3-4-10, Donovan Jackson 0-0-0, Joe Miller 7-0-14, LaQuan Smith 2-1-5, Sinisa Sribljan 1-0-2, Charles Haam 2-0-0, Charles Huggins 1-0-2, Wesley Payne 3-2-8, Thomas Chears 0-0-0, Antoine Norris 0-0-0, Matt Messaro 0-0-0, Mike Messaro 0-0-0, Aaron Mills 0-0-0. Totals 19-9-48.
Olmsted Falls 12 16 11 19 — 58
Kenmore 8 10 13 17 — 48
Three-point goals: Olmsted Falls 5 (Bungard 2, D. Pellerite, P. Pellerite, Sparks), Kenmore 2 (Hearn, Payne). Rebounds: Olmsted Falls 29 (Sparks 17), Kenmore 29 (Smith 11).
Turnovers: Olmsted Falls 12, Kenmore 22.
Total fouls: Olmsted Falls 17, Kenmore 21.
Fouled out: Miller.

CAVALIERS

Pollard remark causes concern

The Associated Press

CLEVELAND — Cleveland Cavaliers center Scot Pollard looked into the camera during a recent game and said, "Hey kids, do drugs."

Pollard was sitting on the bench in street clothes when he made the remark during a 20-second timeout Sunday against Indiana. The Cavaliers didn't find it funny.

"We have spoken with Scot and certainly do not condone his actions," general manager Danny Ferry said in a statement Wednesday. "He regrets his mistake, using inappropriate humor, particularly when he has always been very involved in the community, projecting positive messages to our youth. We will handle the issue internally."

"It was a bad joke," Pollard said in Thursday editions of The Plain Dealer. "That's all it boils down to. There are a number of things people could say about it, but it just turned out it was a bad joke. Obviously, I don't believe that."

Pollard, who has played in only 17 games this season, was not available on Thursday. He would be at practice today, the team said.

BULLETIN BOARD

Schools

CLIPPERS NEED COACH: Clearview High School has an opening for the position of varsity head football coach. Interested candidates are asked to send a letter of interest to Shawn Coakley, Clearview High School, 4700 Broadway Ave., Lorain 44052. Deadline for applications is March 23.

AMHERST SEEKS COACH: Amherst Steele High School is looking for a boys head basketball coach for the 2007-08 season. A limited number of teaching positions may be available. Visit the district website for an application. Interested candidates are asked to contact Bill Miller, athletic director, (440) 988-4433 or bill_miller@amherst.k12.oh.us.

BASKETBALL COACH NEEDED: Black River High School is looking for a head boys varsity basketball coach. Teaching positions are unknown at this time. Interested candidates are asked to submit a letter of interest and resume to Pete Keenan, athletic director, Black River High School, 233 County Road 40, Sullivan 44880. Deadline for applications is Monday.

VOLLEYBALL COACH NEEDED: Southview High School is looking for a head girls volleyball coach. Resumes should be sent to athletic director Bryan Koury, 2350 Pole Avenue, Lorain, 44052, or call (440) 233-2288.